

Reading and commenting on texts

IT'S USEFUL TO BE ABLE TO INTERPRET AND WRITE ABOUT DIFFERENT PIECES OF WRITING.

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When answering a question about a text, a writer needs to understand the question, find the right information in the text, and use it to write a focused answer.

Understand the question

The first step is to read the question and understand what it is asking. Even a well-crafted answer will get no points if it does not answer the question. Underlining the key words in the question will make it easier to focus on what is being asked.

What do you learn from the opening paragraph about...

What are the four main reasons that the writer gives...

How does the writer use language to persuade the reader that...

This question only asks about the opening paragraph, so don't make comments about the rest of the text.

This question is asking specifically about language, so there is no need to write about presentation.

The right information

The next stage is to read the text and look for the relevant information or features. It is useful to underline the words, sentences, or passages that will help answer the question. Sometimes a question will refer to two texts.

- **Read** the whole text first. It is important to get an **overall idea** of what the text is about before analyzing the details.
- Refer to the text frequently, but be **selective**—**don't copy** out whole chunks of text.
- Become more **familiar** with different types of texts and the techniques they use by **reading** texts from **everyday life**, such as newspapers and even junk mail.

TEXT 1

Are your parents always nagging you to eat breakfast?

Well, this time they're right. In the morning, your body needs fuel, just like a car. Once you've filled up, you'll be ready to hit the road.

compares the body to a car

Underline sections that will be useful when writing an answer.

Write observations and notes around the text.

This extract has the same subject matter as Text 1, but is written in complex, scientific language.

TEXT 2

Recent studies outline the many health benefits of eating a nutritious breakfast. In the morning, the body's glycogen stores start to deplete. Without breakfast, a person soon begins to feel fatigued.